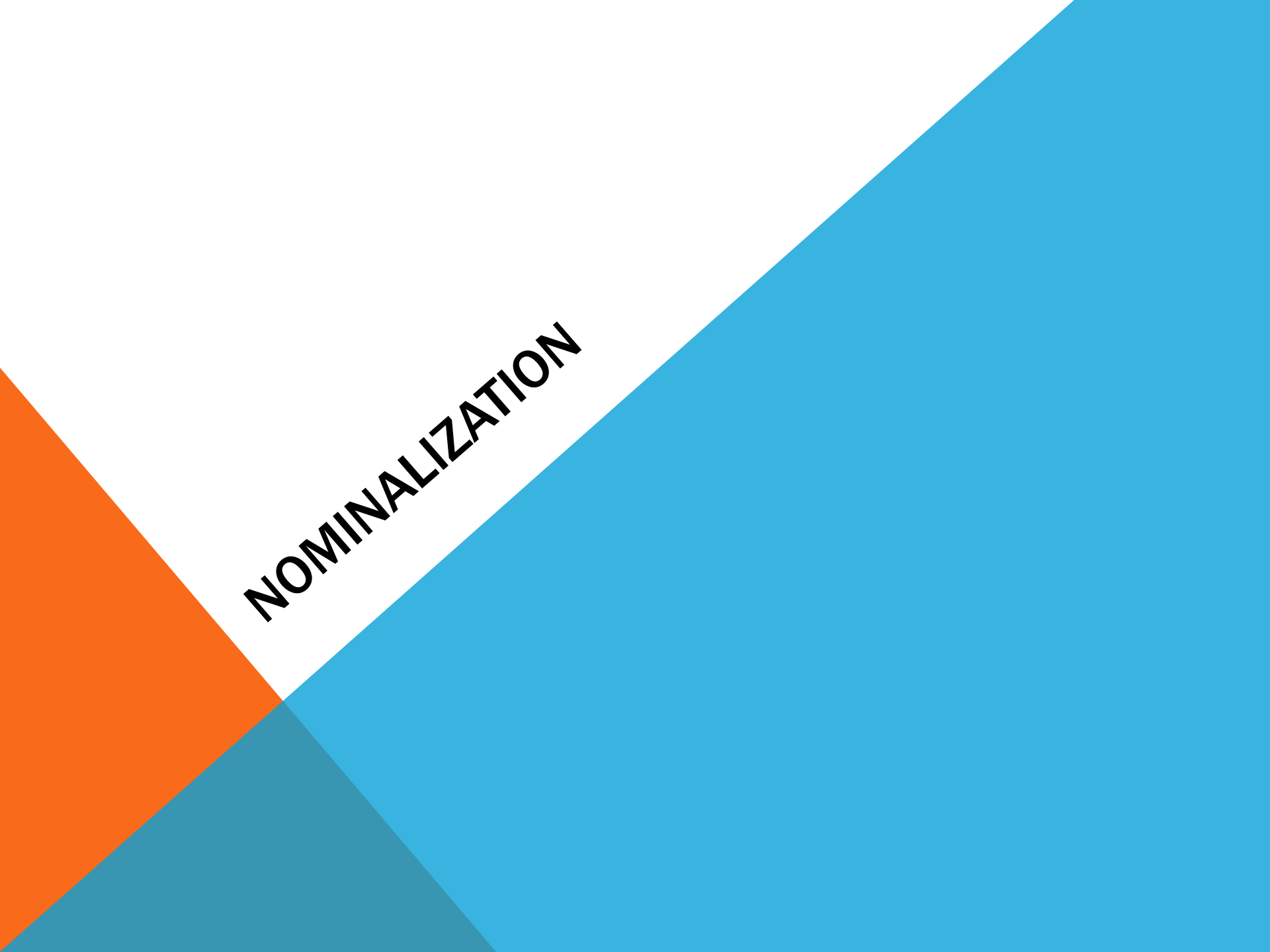




NOMINALIZATION

Nominalizations are nouns that are created from adjectives (words that describe nouns) or verbs (action words). For example, “interference” is a nominalization of “interfere,” “decision” is a nominalization of “decide,” and “argument” is a nominalization of “argue.”



So, why does this matter?

First, it is important to understand what these words mean when you see them.

Second, if you are aware of what nominalizations are, you may use them to make your writing easier to understand.

Remember, the two most basic units of a sentence are the subject and the verb.

Subject → Verb

Character → Action

Person or Thing → Doing Something

Sentences often start with a subject followed by a verb, and are easily understood according to this order. For example,

Many children → experience worries when they go to school for the first time.

Elephants → argue over small concerns, just like humans.



NOW, you might see some with nominalizations, like the ones below:

The experience of children with respect to being at school for the first time is common.

Arguments over small concerns are something elephants have, as well as humans.

This second set of sentences is more difficult to understand because the use of the nominalization means there must be more words in the sentence.

Subject → *Verb*: easy to follow

Subject → *Long strings of nominalizations and other forms* → *Verb*: hard to follow

Here is an example of the difference between the two structures:

The group discussed how to plan the surprise party.

The discussion of the group was about how to surprise the girl with the birthday without her knowing.



Nouns

Intention
Intervention

Distortion

Evolution
Interference

Discrimination

Decision
Assumption

Collection

Investigation

Expansion

Disagreement

Discussion

Argument

Failure

Verbs

Intend
Intervene

Distort

Evolve
Interfere

Discriminate

Decide
Assume

Collect

Investigate

Expand

Disagree

Discuss

Argue

Fail



Nouns

Applicability

Carelessness

Difficulty

Intensity

Shiftness

Happiness

Slowness

Fear

Elder

Adjectives

Applicable

Careless

Difficult

Intense

Shifty

Happy

Slow

Afraid

Elderly



As you can see, the endings of the nominalized forms vary, but many end in “-ion/tion”, “-ment,” “-ity/-ty”, and “-ness.”

Are nominalizations always a bad choice?

No. Sometimes, nominalizations can be useful:

When the nominalization is familiar to your reader as a character (happiness), it can be treated as a character. Example: *Happiness has many causes and effects.*

When you are making a general statement that focuses more on the idea than the actual actors in the sentence. Example: *The distribution of the pizzas was fair.*

Be sure to remember that even in a case where a nominalization is appropriate, you should not use them too often in too short of a space.

